

Getting Ready: How to Prepare for Surgery

Steps to take in the days and weeks before your gallbladder surgery.

Your Pre-Op Appointment

Before surgery, you'll attend a pre-assessment visit to confirm you're ready for surgery and anesthesia. This usually includes a review of your medical history, basic bloodwork, and sometimes an EKG. Bring a complete list of your medications, including over-the-counter drugs and supplements.

Managing Your Medications

- Tell your surgical team about every medication and supplement you take, including aspirin, ibuprofen, and herbal supplements.
- Blood thinners (such as warfarin, clopidogrel, or newer anticoagulants) often need to be paused several days before surgery — only stop them if your surgeon or prescribing doctor tells you to.
- Continue any medication your team specifically tells you to keep taking, even on the morning of surgery, with just a small sip of water.

Eating and Drinking Before Surgery

The standard instruction is nothing to eat after midnight the night before your surgery. Your surgical team may give you more specific guidance about clear liquids or small sips of water for medications — follow their instructions exactly, since eating or drinking against instructions can require your surgery to be delayed or rescheduled for safety.

The Night Before

- Shower with the antiseptic soap provided, if your team gave you one.
- Get a good night's sleep.
- Lay out loose, comfortable clothing for the next day.
- Pack a small bag with your ID, insurance card, medication list, and a phone charger.

Arranging Your Ride and Support

You will need a responsible adult to drive you home after surgery and to stay with you for the first 24 hours. This is a firm requirement — you will not be discharged without a confirmed ride, since you cannot safely drive or be alone right after anesthesia.

What to Bring

- Photo ID and insurance card
- A list of current medications and dosages
- Glasses, hearing aids, or dentures (with a case)
- A form of payment if needed for co-pays

What to Leave at Home

- Jewelry, watches, and other valuables
- Large amounts of cash
- Contact lenses (wear glasses instead, if you can)

Morning-Of Checklist

1. Nothing to eat or drink unless specifically instructed.
2. Take only approved medications with a small sip of water.
3. Wear loose, comfortable clothing.
4. Bring your bag and ID.
5. Confirm your ride is ready to go with you and take you home.

Questions Worth Asking Your Surgical Team

- Will I go home the same day, or should I plan for an overnight stay?
- Which of my regular medications should I pause, and when?
- What pain medication will I be prescribed, and how do I take it safely?
- When can I shower, drive, and return to work?

This information is general education about a common procedure and does not replace advice from your own surgeon and care team. Instructions can vary by patient — always follow what your care team tells you, and call them with any questions or concerns.